

Yoga Nidra or Deep Relaxation

15 minutes

Benefits – Evidenced based approach for treatment of anxiety, stress, insomnia and PTSD.

In preparation for YOGA NIDRA, DEEP RELAXATION, you may want to put on socks or sweaters as the body may cool down. If comfortable, place a pillow under the knees and using a blanket. (Pause) Then lie down on the back with legs at least hip distance apart, arms at least six inches away from the body with palms facing up. This is Savaasana or the corpse pose.

We will be going through the body, tensing it part by part, raising each part a few inches off the floor. When asked to release, just relax all the muscles of that part and let it drop to the floor as if a string from a puppet has been cut.

Bringing the awareness to the right leg. Stretch it out. Tightening all the muscles of the leg. Inhale, raise it a few inches, squeeze.

(Pause 5 seconds.)

Releasing. Gently rolling the leg and relaxing it completely.

(Same with the left leg.)

Stretching out the right arm and splaying the fingers wide. Making a fist, tightening the arm. Inhaling, raise it a few inches, squeeze, squeeze...

(Pause 5 seconds.)

Releasing. Rolling the arm gently from side to side and resting it with the palm up.

(Same with the left arm)

Bringing the awareness to the buttocks. Inhaling. Tightening the buttocks muscles and squeezing...

Releasing. Feeling the hips sinking down.

Bringing the awareness to the abdomen. Inhaling deeply through the nose, puffing up the abdomen like a balloon. Continue taking in air to your comfort. Hold, hold, hold.

(Pause 7 seconds.)

Opening the mouth and allowing the air to gush out. Relaxing the abdomen.

Bringing the awareness to the chest. Inhaling deeply, expanding the chest. Taking in a little more air and hold, hold, hold.

(Pause 7 seconds.)

Opening the mouth and releasing. Relaxing the chest.

Leaving the arms on the floor, sliding the shoulders up towards the ears...Squeeze, Squeeze...Relax. Now lifting the shoulders and squeezing them together in front of the chest...Squeeze, Squeeze, Squeeze...Relax. Sliding the shoulders down toward the ribcage...Relaxing. Bringing the shoulders toward the feet....Relaxing. Bringing the shoulders toward each other behind the back.

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Squeezing the muscles of the neck as if you were going to lift the head off the floor. Releasing. Gently rolling the head from side to side, mentally relaxing the neck muscles. Returning the head to the center and relaxing.

(10-15 seconds)

Bringing the awareness to the face. Gently moving the jaw up and down...Relax. Squeeze the lips together in a pout...Relax. Suck in the cheeks...Relax. Wrinkling the nose, squeezing the eyes...Relaxing. Raising the eyebrows, wrinkling the forehead...Relaxing. Now squeezing all the muscles in the face toward the tip of the nose...Relaxing.

Next, you will be focusing the mind on each part of the body, to releasing any remaining tension. If you detect any subtle tension anywhere, sending a mental message to completely relax it.

Make any needed physical adjustments. Trying remain perfectly still for the rest of Yoga Nidra.

We'll now be moving through parts of the body sending mental messages to release and relax.

Without moving any part of the body, becoming aware of the toes and sending them a mental message to relax. Relaxing the feet, ankles, lower legs, knees and thighs. Relaxing the buttocks and pelvis; the abdominal muscles, the internal organs. Relaxing the rib cage, chest, heart and lungs.

Bringing the awareness to the lower back, and relaxing it. Moving up the spine, relaxing the middle back, the upper back, and the shoulder blades.

Bringing awareness to the hands; relaxing the fingers, palms, and back of the hands. Relaxing the wrists, forearms, elbows and upper arms. Relaxing the shoulders, neck, and throat. Letting go, letting go. Relaxing the chin and jaw, the tongue, and mouth. Relaxing the lips, cheeks, the nose, the eyes, forehead, ears, temples, sides of the head, and the top of the head.

Observing the body; feeling that there is no tension anywhere in the body. As the body relaxes completely, keeping the mind alert.

(10 seconds)

Bringing the awareness to the breath. When the body is relaxed, the breath becomes very relaxed and subtle. Allowing it flow in and out by itself. Remaining a witness to the breath.

(1 minute: including the instruction and silence)

Becoming a witness to the mind. Allowing the thoughts and feelings to arise and float away much like clouds passing across the landscape of the mind on a summer's day. Not holding onto the thoughts and feelings or pushing them away. Simply witnessing.

(1 minute; includes the instruction and silence)

Going deeply within to the heart center, to the place where peace and stillness reside. The stillness from which all things arise. Enjoying the peace and stillness of the true self.

(Five minutes of silence)

Ommm.

Bringing the awareness back to the breath and observing its gentle flow. [Pause] Gently deepening the breath. [Pause] Now taking a full, three part breath. Feeling that prana or vital life force is filling every cell in the body, relaxing, refreshing, renewing.

Slowly beginning to wiggle the fingers and toes...delicately rolling the arms from side to side...

Gently rolling the legs from side to side...give the body a good stretch perhaps as if you were awakening from sleep. Rolling over onto the right side if you wish to maintain inner drawn awareness or onto the left side if you wish to feel more alert and energized.

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Drawing the knees in towards the chest and perhaps using the arm as a pillow. Allow the body to transition slowly.

Gently drawing the body to a seated position, bringing the peace and stillness with you.